THROUGH THE HOUR-LONG chat with *BT*, Nyrika Holkar easily shifts from one topic to another with poise and calm. It could be a question on Godrej Enterprises Group's diversified businesses or how she views technology and digital or how she keeps her team motivated. As Executive Director of the entity that runs diverse businesses such as consumer (home appliances, furniture and fittings, locks and security), aerospace, commercial appliances, advanced engineering, intralogistics and real estate, Holkar is the custodian of an enviable legacy, one that she must make future ready. She has been a key part of the growth story of a group that has stood for quality across generations.

The large meeting room in her office in Mumbai's Vikhroli is simple but functional. A peep outside reveals a spacious open office that is quietly buzzing with activity. Academically, she first earned an undergraduate degree in philosophy and economics from Colorado College, doubling it with a master's in law from University College in London. The move into the family business (her mother, Smita and Jamshyd Godrej are siblings) came after a six-year stint with AZB & Partners. In an interview with Krishna Gopalan, Holkar elaborates on the business today and her vision for tomorrow. Edited excerpts:

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You have a rich legacy with the Godrej brand name. Do you view that as a strategic advantage in a dynamic business environment?

We have been around for 129 years. The natural inclination would be to preserve everything or to change everything. Neither of the two is very helpful.

One must identify the elements that are enduring and specific aspects that need to be changed. The Godrej brand enjoys tremendous trust, but we must build on that and ensure it is renewed in every generation. If we look at today's younger consumers, we need to understand they are choosing us because we are a brand that delivers on their aspirations. The fact is nobody will choose us for nostalgia.

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Godrej is a diversified group. How much of a challenge is to preserve the rich past and yet get it right on the more contemporary businesses?

In consumer businesses, while quality and trust are something the brand stands for and these remain key drivers of purchase. For us, the opportunity is to make the brand more design forward and tech enabled, and to get the price value equation right so that we can give consumers a strong value proposition. It also means that the proposition needs be communicated effectively. For example, a thing like steel kitchens that are ideally suited for the hard use of Indian kitchens and can withstand high humidity, pests, and corrosion is important to communicate to customers.

However, in the industrial businesses, the challenge is different. Quality and trust remain the most critical factors for a repeat purchase but again, design becomes the differentiator. As we move from build-to-print to build-to-spec, we have to build a different set of capabilities and we have to be able to integrate software and electronics with mechanical fabrication.

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Technology is at the core of your businesses. Where are you on the journey to becoming a more tech-led organisation?

The insight from our consumer interactions is that we are not perceived as being design-forward.

So, we decided to use AI to understand trends from different sectors, like the automotive industry, OTTs, and hospitality, to translate trends for home furni-